A mix of scents struck Léa—camphor, pine and something sharper, almost metallic. But it was the licorice root that stood above the others, reminding her of the winters when her mother had given them the root to suck on to soothe their sore throats. A man stood with his back to the sisters, speaking to the woman at the counter as a second woman emerged from behind a green velvet curtain at the sound of the bell. She addressed them in German.

Léa stepped forward, steadying her hands on the counter. She realized that she should have practiced her German because her words tangled, slipping between French and German. “I would like to buy medicine for an eye infection,” she managed to say, her voice thin with embarrassment at her garbled pronunciation.

The woman puckered her lips as she examined Léa’s eye. “For you?”

“No, someone else.”

The woman wagged a finger at her. “*Nein*.”

“But her eye is swollen.” Léa made a round shape with her hand. “Like a bee sting. It’s all red. Her shift won’t end until after the pharmacy is closed, so I’ve come for her.”

She felt the man at the counter turn and glance at her, then brush past her as he took his leave. She kept repeating the German words she knew—*medizin*, *rot*, *auge*—hoping that somehow she’d make herself understood. But the more she said, the more the woman’s position hardened. Eventually, Léa gave up, and left with Rose.

Outside, the cold night air blew hard in her face and her eyes watered. The sky was solid black, as though someone had dipped a brush in ink and painted over the moon and stars.

“Mademoiselle, perhaps I can help?” a man said in perfect French.

Léa turned. He wore round glasses, but she could see beyond the lenses that his eyes were a soft, warm brown.

“I overheard you in the pharmacy. Is it conjunctivitis that your friend has?”

“I’m not sure.”

“A poultice of Euphrasia can help heal an infection of the eye.”

“Oh?”

“Yes, it’s a compress made from wildflowers. The eye is quite good at healing itself. The herbs will relieve the pain and quicken the healing.”